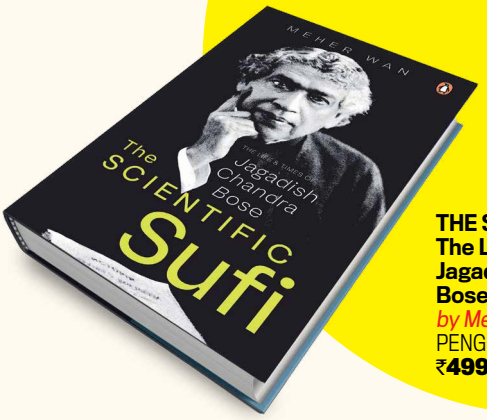
Whirling Dervish of Indian Science

BOOKS

A NEW BIOGRAPHY SHEDS LIGHT ON **JAGADISH CHANDRA BOSE**, SAID TO BE THE FATHER OF MODERN SCIENCE IN INDIA



THE SCIENTIFIC SUFI
The Life & Times of Jagadish Chandra Bose
by Meher Wan
PENGUIN VIKING
₹499; 264 pages

Sir J.C. Bose was the preeminent experimental scientist of his time. His work on radio transmission and the properties of millimetre radio waves preceded that of Marconi and others who not only got the credit for it but also managed to make money out of it. Later in his career, he worked on the response of plants to various stimuli, for which he developed several ingenious pieces of equipment.

Born in 1858, Bose had a relatively privileged upbringing since his father was a civil servant in Bengal. After obtaining his undergraduate degree at St Xavier's College, he went to England to study medicine but couldn't do so because of ill health. He went on to study natural science at Cambridge under some of the most well-known scientists of that time.

He returned and joined Presidency College in Calcutta, where he taught till his retirement. Despite a hostile administration, he managed to do his path-breaking research there. Later, when his work got recognition abroad, the government started funding his research as well as his lecture tours to Europe. After his retirement, he continued his research in plant behaviour and biophysics and also founded the Bose Institute, where he remained till his death in 1937.

Meher Wan's biography of J.C. Bose is an attempt not just to describe the life and work of this extraordinary scientist but also place them in the context of their colonial environment. His earlier years, which were decisive in shaping his personality, are described in great detail, as is the role played by his father. Bose's work on the radio as well as on plant physiology is explained clearly, though with some repetition.

This biography seeks to describe J.C. Bose's life and work in the context of his colonial environment

The style of writing, however, is somewhat jarring. It reminds one of the way in which biographies of great men are written for 'young adult' readers. Describing Bose's relationship as a child with an ex-dacoit, we have, "They have the stagnation of a deep ocean due to their experiences and waves of their desires bounce on the shores of their memories." On the fear felt by Bose as a child, we have, "In his stubbornness, a person feels all the creepy caves of fear in the palace." Mildly amusing at first, these soon get annoying and detract from the book's flow.

And then there are errors; some are minor, like the famous scientist George Stokes being mentioned as 'Strokes'. But there are also some bloopers. "In 1913, J.C. Bose retired after completing fifty-five years at Presidency College." This could have been possible only if he had been appointed a Professor as soon as he was born! That 'kala azar' is caused by a parasitic bacterium—it's caused by a parasitic protozoa.

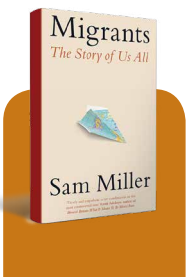
The book is advertised as "the definitive English biography of the father of modern science in India, Sir J.C. Bose". Well, this book definitely is not. ■

Shobhit Mahajan

To Move is to Live, to Live is to Move

Sam Miller's *Migrants* takes a sweeping view of migration and sets it at the centre of the human story

MIGRANTS
The Story of Us All
By Sam Miller
ABACUS (HACHETTE)
₹899; 400 pages



What is the common thread uniting the Neanderthals, Turkish guest workers, Christopher Columbus and the Trojan prince Aeneas? They were all migrants. The Neanderthals moved around seasonally, guest workers travelled from Turkey to Germany for work in the 1960s, Columbus roved the world in search of continents and the mythical Aeneas roamed until he arrived in Rome. All of them feature in Sam Miller's sweeping historical account of human movement, *Migrants: The Story of Us All*. Miller, a journalist and former BBC correspondent who has himself traversed several countries, parses the entirety of human history through the lens of migration. It is his aim, he writes in the prologue, to "restore migration to the heart of the human story", to bust the "myth of sedentarism".

Modern debates around migration are charged, political hot buttons that boil down to visas and borders. The news is full of images of North Africans fleeing to Europe, or Mexicans trying to cross into the US. In the contemporary imagination, the word itself may conjure up images of desperation and poverty. But migrants are so much more, in Miller's telling. His thesis is simple: migration is the throughline of the human story, no matter how settled we believe ourselves to be, ultimately we are all children of migrants.

Starting from the earliest humans, who dispersed out of Africa, Miller dredges up episodes from the past to fortify his position. For his purpose, the word 'migrant' is value-free. It thus encompasses colonial adventurers, West African slaves as well as Jewish refugee communities.

Migrants is an enormous work of synthesis, and Miller's choices are both obvious and idiosyncratic, as any panoramic view of history must be. Along the way, he unravels some popular myths; the Neanderthals are not quite the dim-witted ancestors we have been told they are, and the Vandals vandalised little.

Miller has a relaxed style and leavens the telling with charming personal interludes—his potted family history, his grand-aunt Polly's flight from the embers of the Russian empire, his quest for answers in his own DNA. Throughout, he is careful of acknowledging his own privileges; perhaps too often at pains to remind us that while he, too, is a migrant, he suffers from none of the backlash visited upon other kinds of migrants. ■

Bhavya Dore